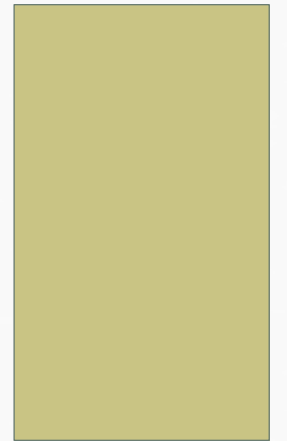


ADHD, HOARDING DISORDER, OR BOTH:
STRATEGIES TO MANAGE CLUTTER AND DISORGANIZATION

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AGENDA

- Define clutter and disorganization.
- Describe differences and similarities between HD-related and ADHD-related factors that contribute to clutter and disorganization.
- What can help.

CLUTTER

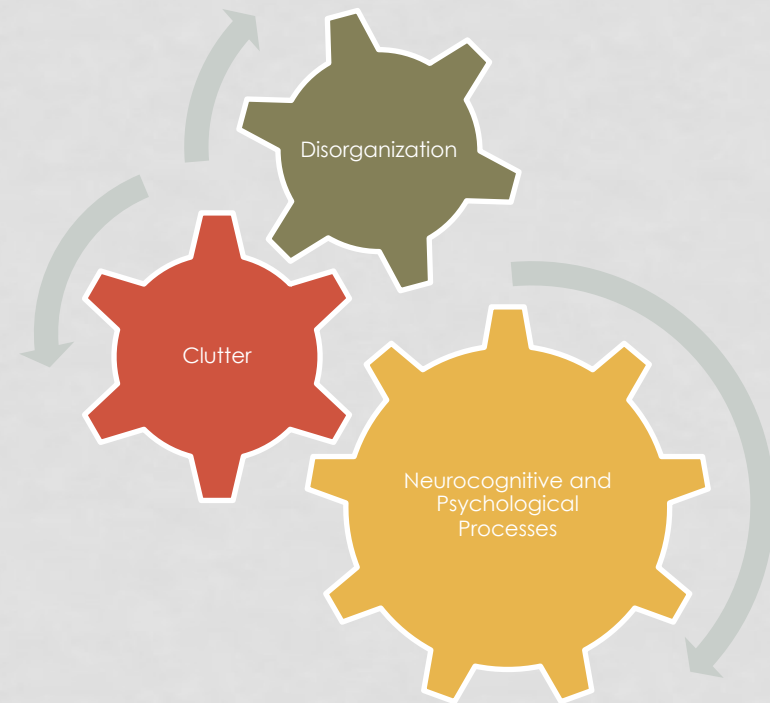
- Clutter is a collection of disorganized possessions scattered about living spaces.
- Clutter is a feature of life for most people.
- People have different tolerances for clutter.
- Increase in clutter can be a natural response to changes in living circumstances (e.g., downsizing) and/or functional capacity (e.g., aging).
- Zero tolerance for clutter is neither easily achievable nor necessary.

THERE'S CLUTTER, AND THEN THERE'S CLUTTER

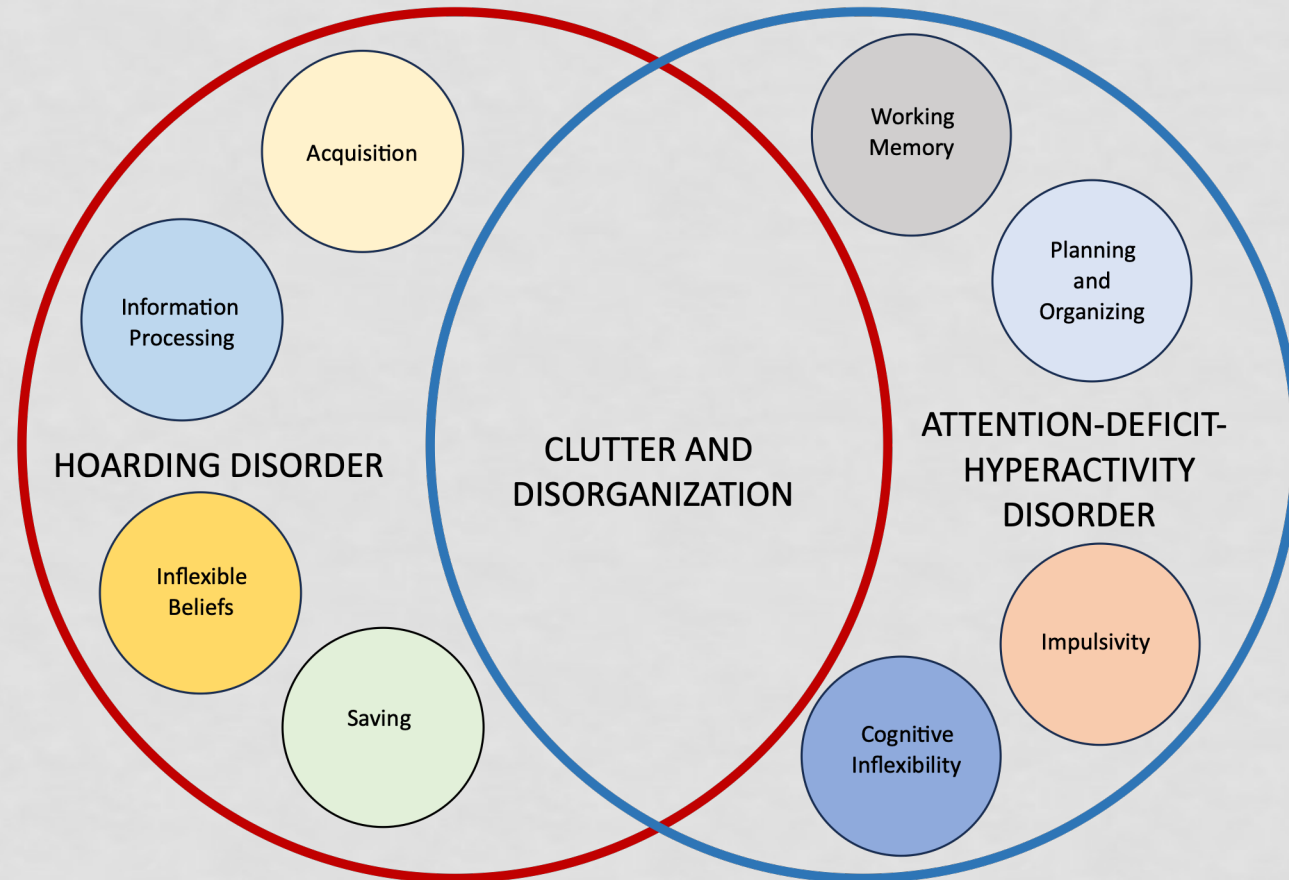
- **Distress:** When level of clutter causes significant distress due to isolation, relationship distress, and difficulties living.
- **Disruption:** When level of clutter makes it difficult to complete activities of daily living (e.g. washing clothes, finding keys, paying bills) or time and money costs.
- **Duration:** When distress and disruption from clutter persists over time and not in response to a single event (e.g., relocation).

CLUTTER AND DISORGANIZATION

- Clutter can result from psychological processes that fuel excessive saving and acquiring.
- Disorganization can result from neurocognitive processes that contribute to difficulties managing level of clutter.
- Disorganization is both a consequence of clutter and of attempts to manage it.



CLUTTER AND DISORGANIZATION



HOARDING DISORDER

HOARDING BEHAVIOR VS. HOARDING DISORDER

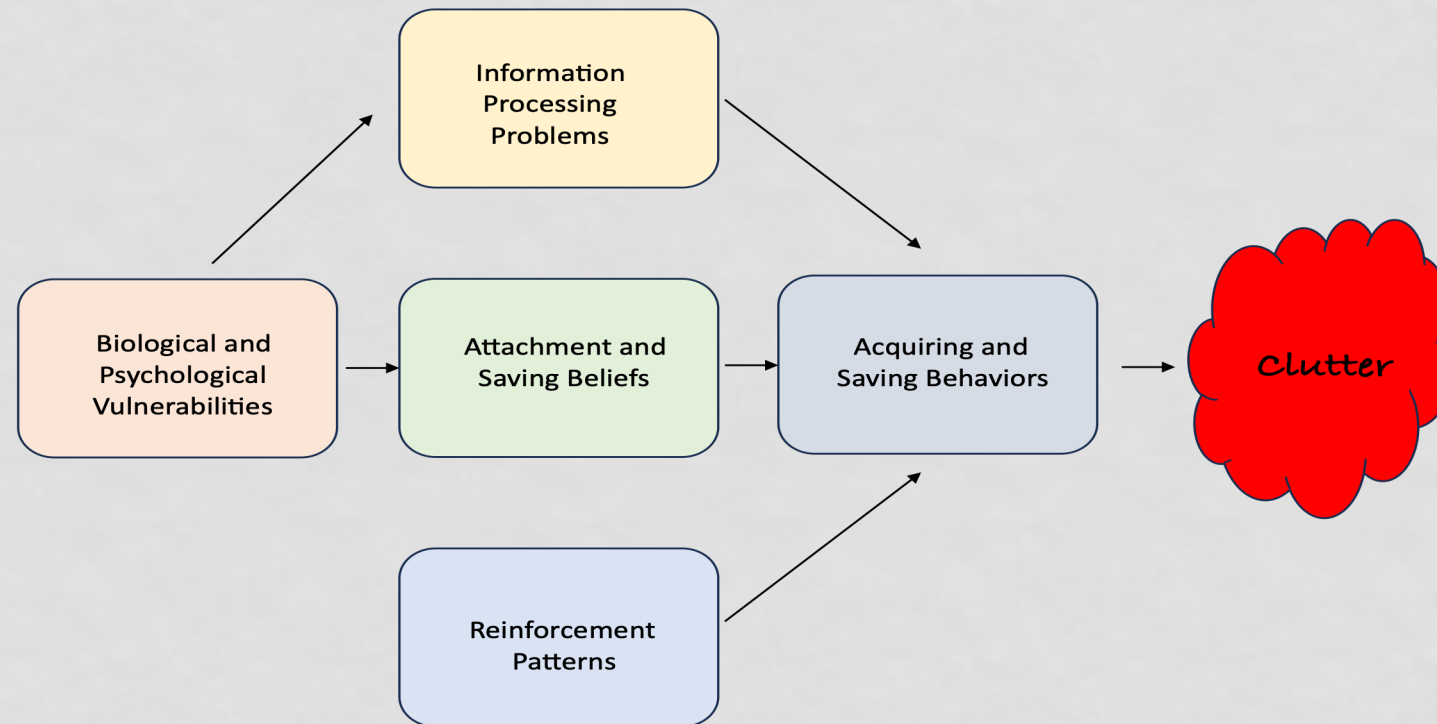
Hoarding Behavior

- Hoarding behaviors can result from medical conditions (e.g., dementia, brain injury or stroke, Prader-Willi syndrome, velocardio facial syndrome).
- Hoarding behaviors can result from psychological conditions (e.g., autism spectrum disorders, bipolar disorder, eating disorders, psychotic disorders).
- Acute onset of hoarding behaviors suggest a medical-related onset.

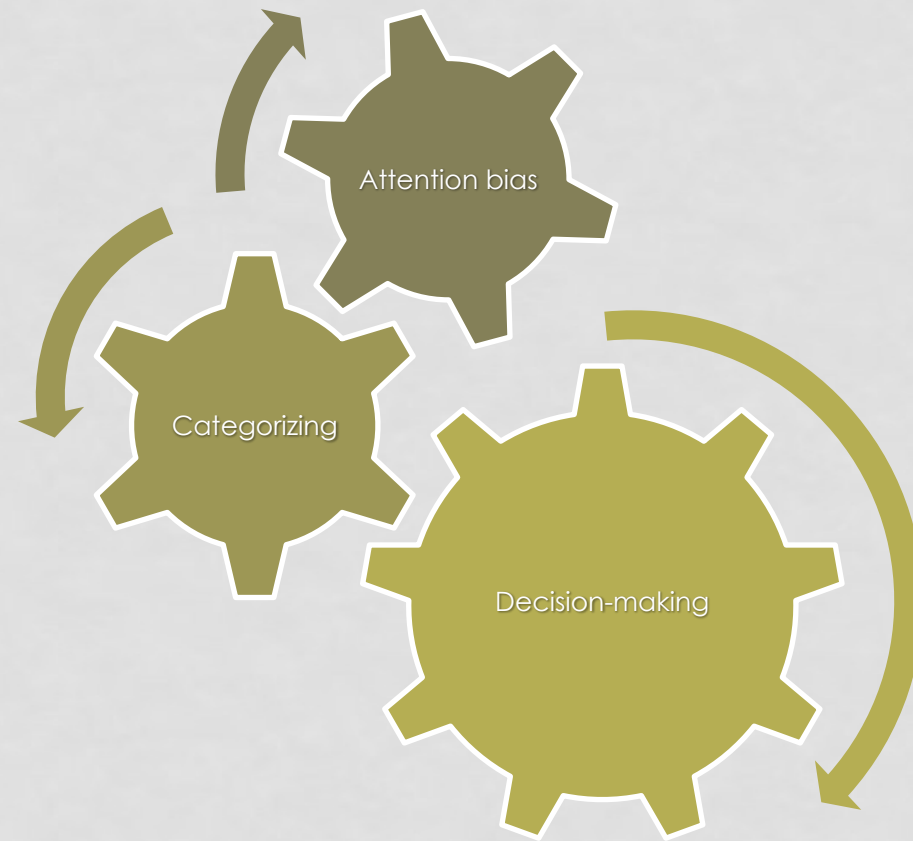
Hoarding Disorder

- Difficulty discarding objects due to urges to save.
- Symptoms result in accumulation of possessions that clutter living areas.
- Distress or interference.
- Not better accounted for by medical condition or by other psychiatric conditions.
- Diagnostic specifier: with excessive acquisition, poor insight.

HOARDING DISORDER: FACTORS THAT CONTRIBUTE TO CLUTTER



INFORMATION PROCESSING FACTORS

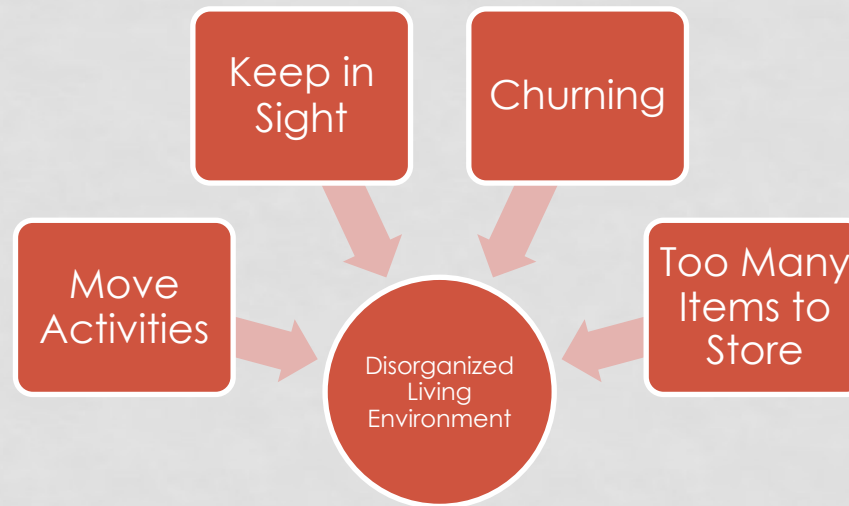


ACQUIRING AND DISORGANIZATION FACTORS

Acquiring Factors



Disorganization Factors

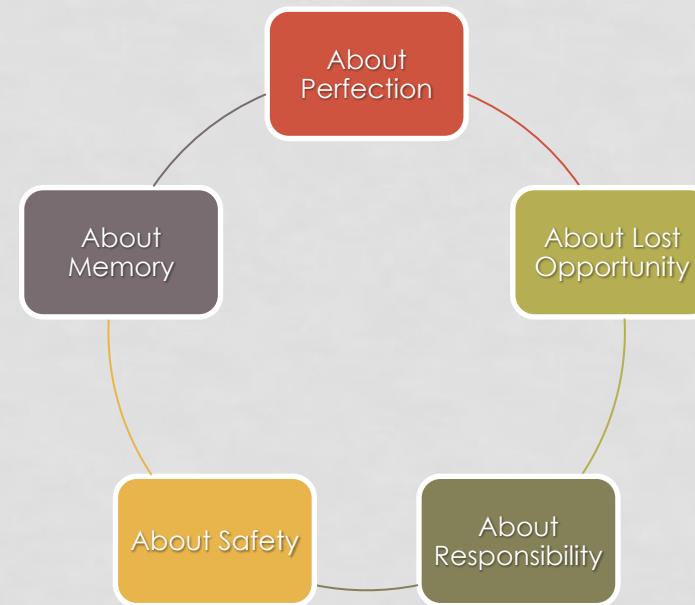


SAVING FACTORS

Emotional Attachment Factors

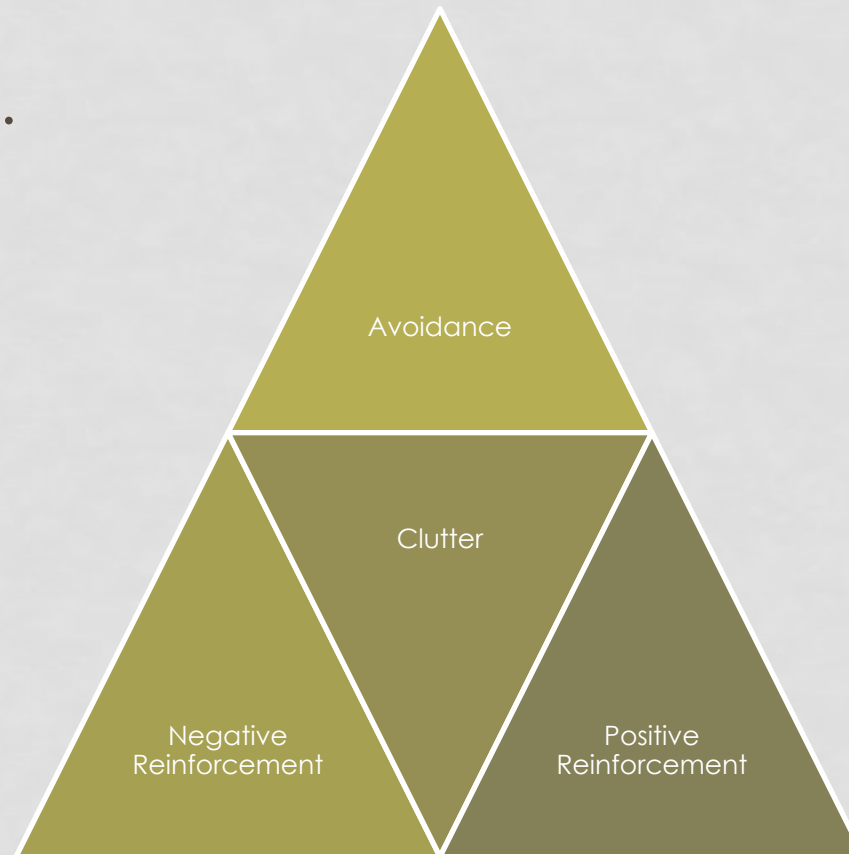


Erroneous Belief Factors



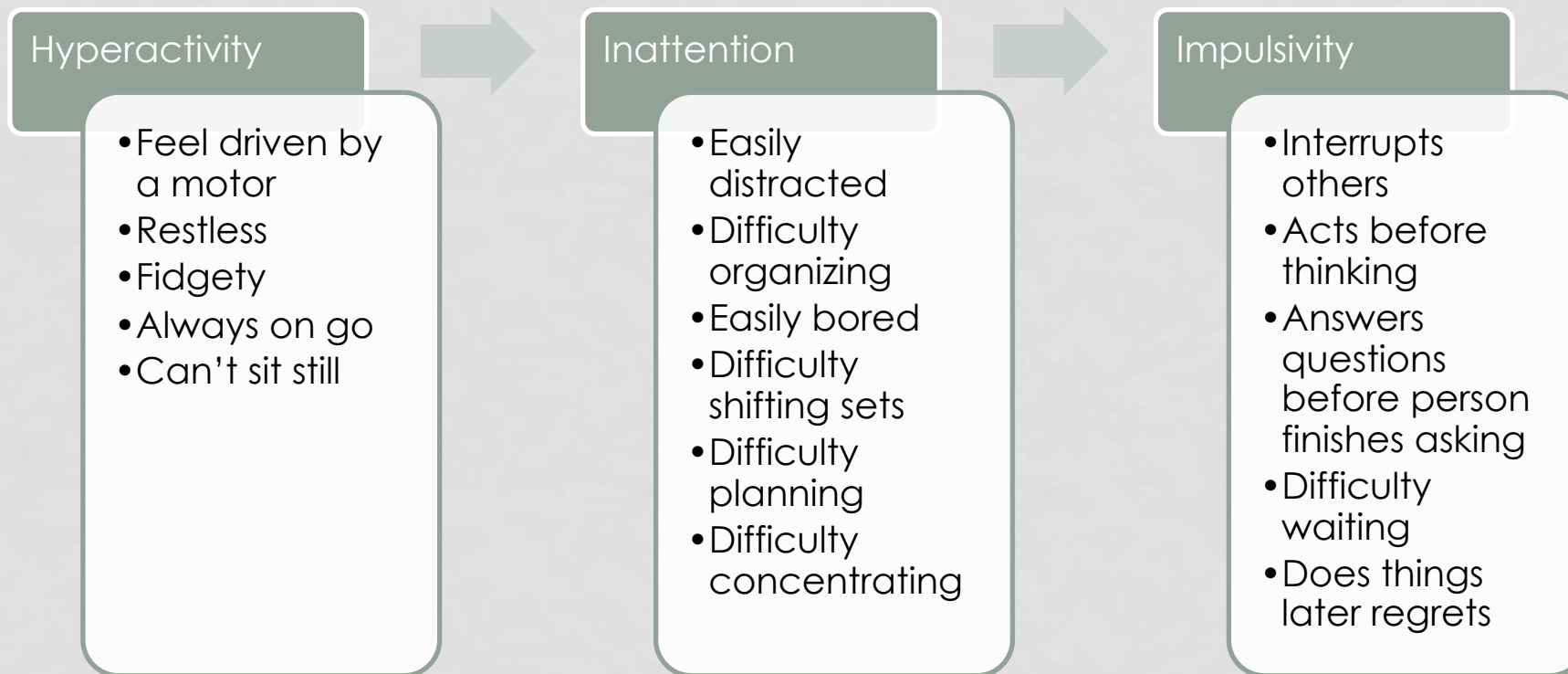
REINFORCEMENT FACTORS

- Stop or postpone clearing.
- Avoid discarding.
- Avoid organizing.
- Avoid making decisions.
- Avoid starting to clear.
- Save item.
- Acquire items.
- Churn items.

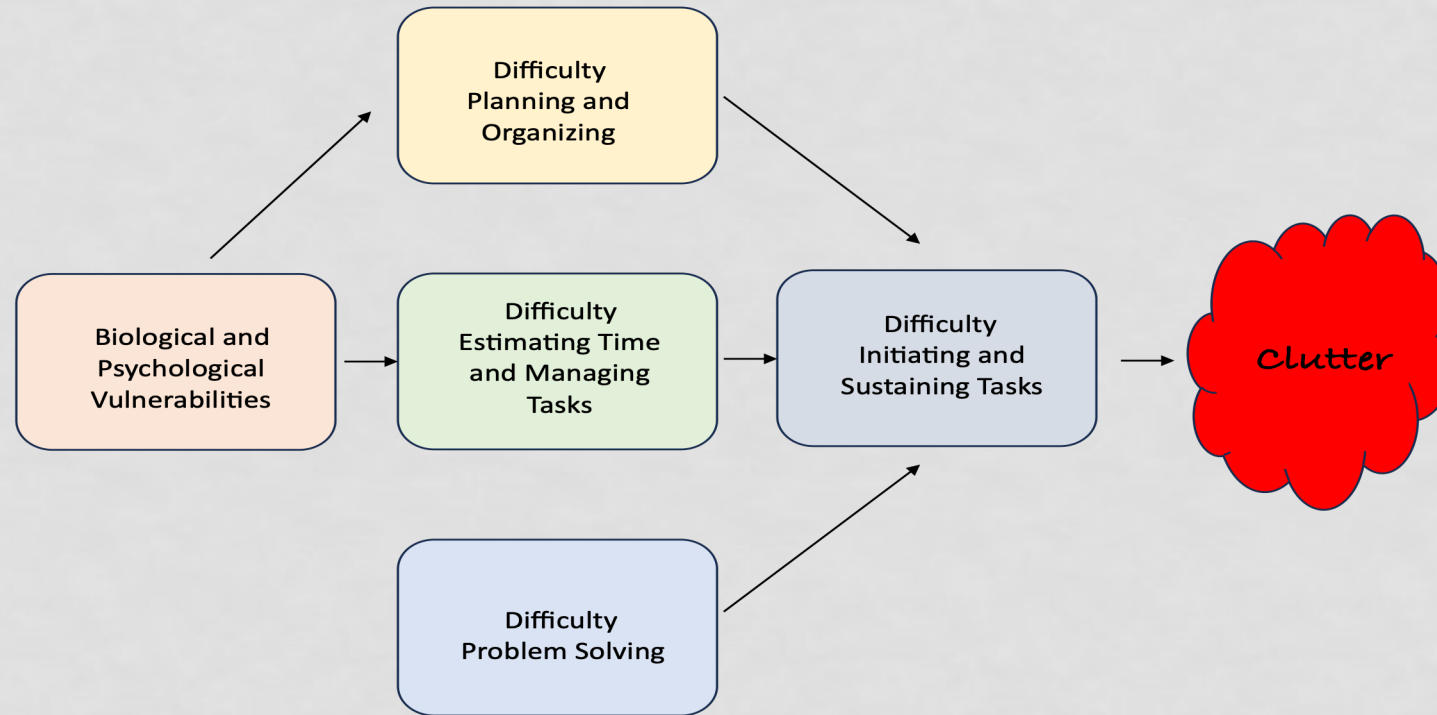


ATTENTION-DEFICIT HYPERACTIVITY DISORDER

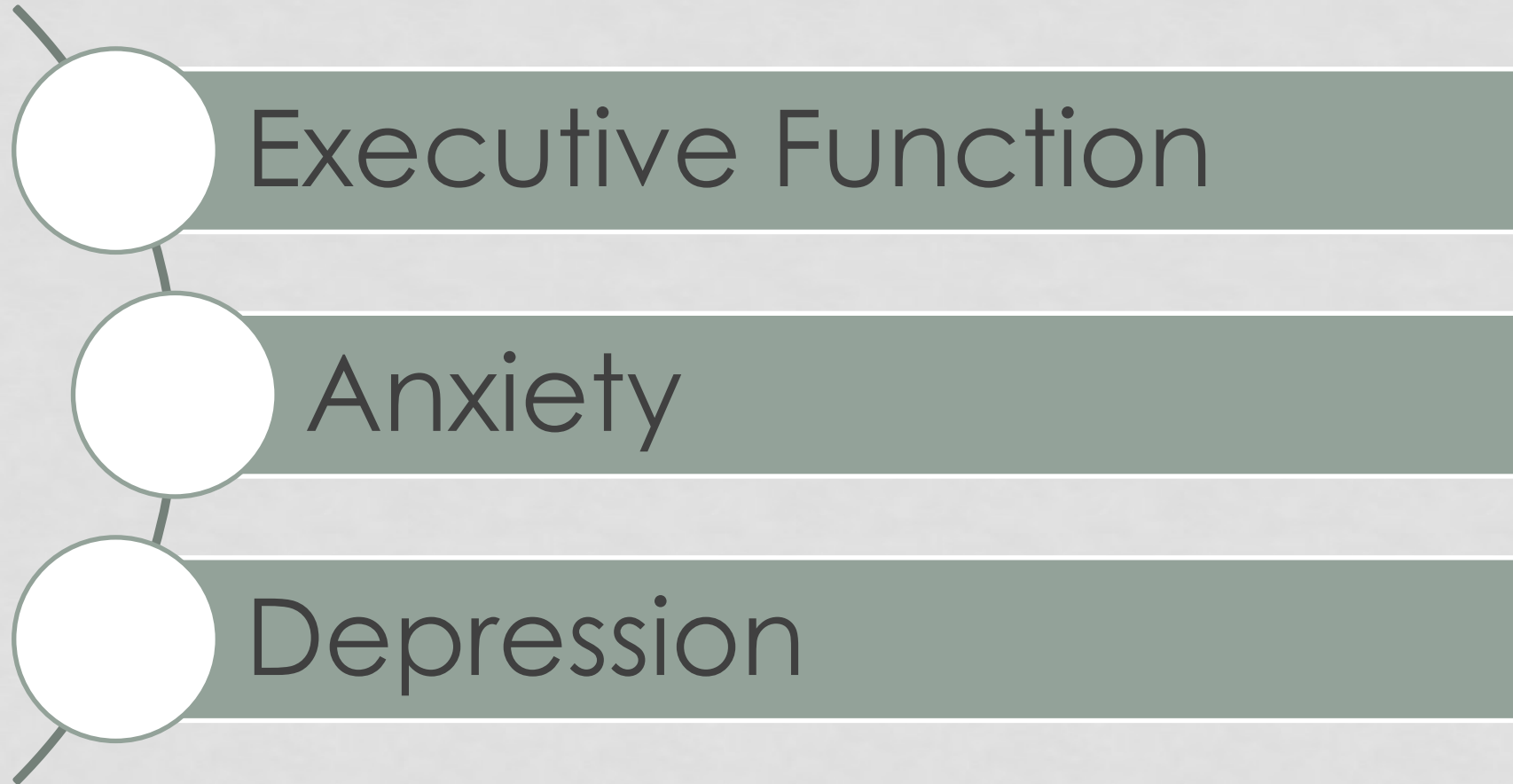
ATTENTION DEFICIT HYPERACTIVITY DISORDER



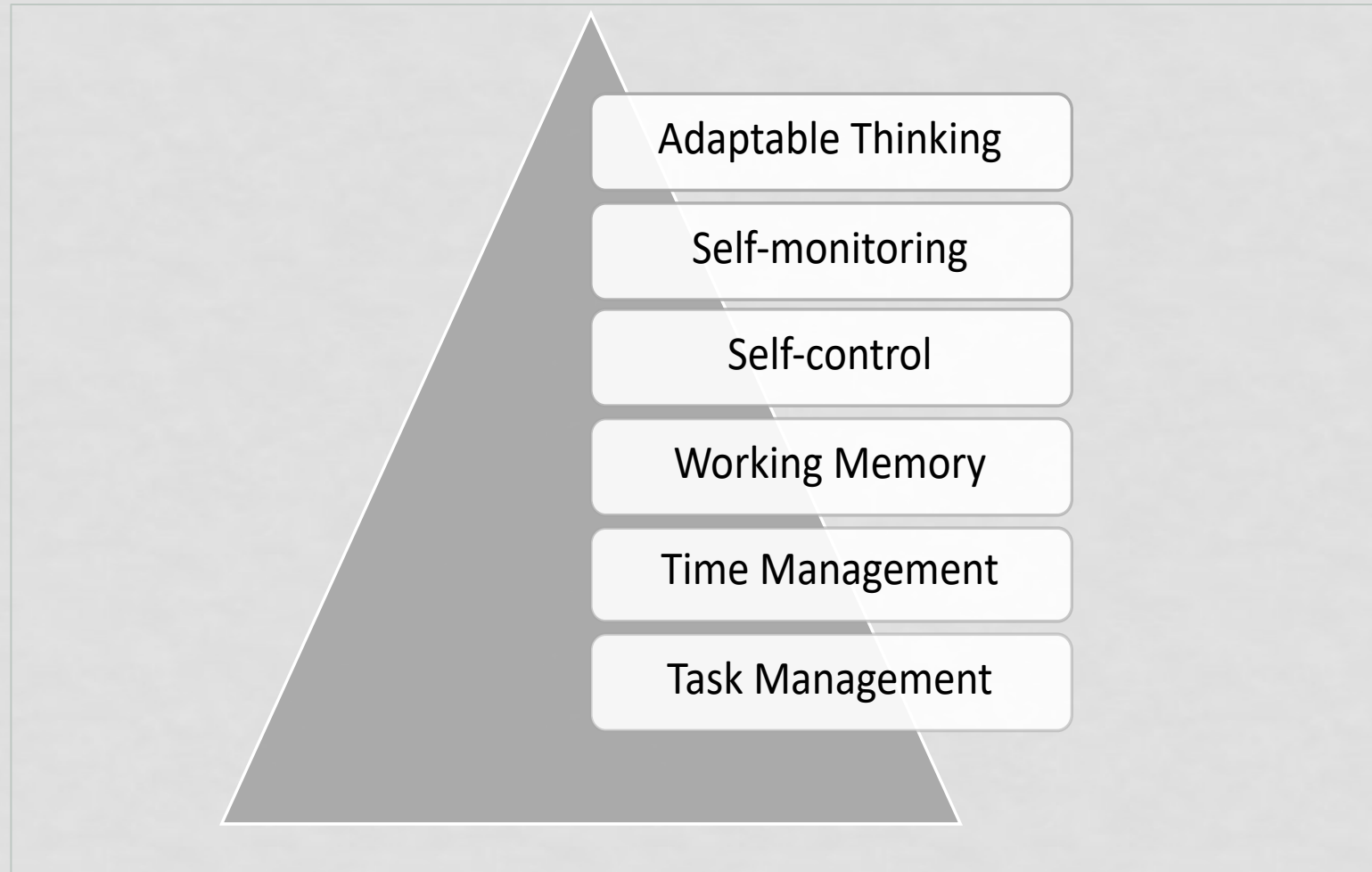
ADHD: FACTORS THAT CONTRIBUTE TO CLUTTER



TASK INITIATION AND PERSISTENCE



EXECUTIVE FUNCTION FACTORS



TASK MANAGEMENT WEAKNESSES

- Weaknesses in organizing and planning skills make it difficult to identify the logical and explicit steps required to complete tasks required to declutter and organize living environments.
- Weaknesses in organizing and planning skills result in feeling easily overwhelmed which leads to procrastination and task abandonment.

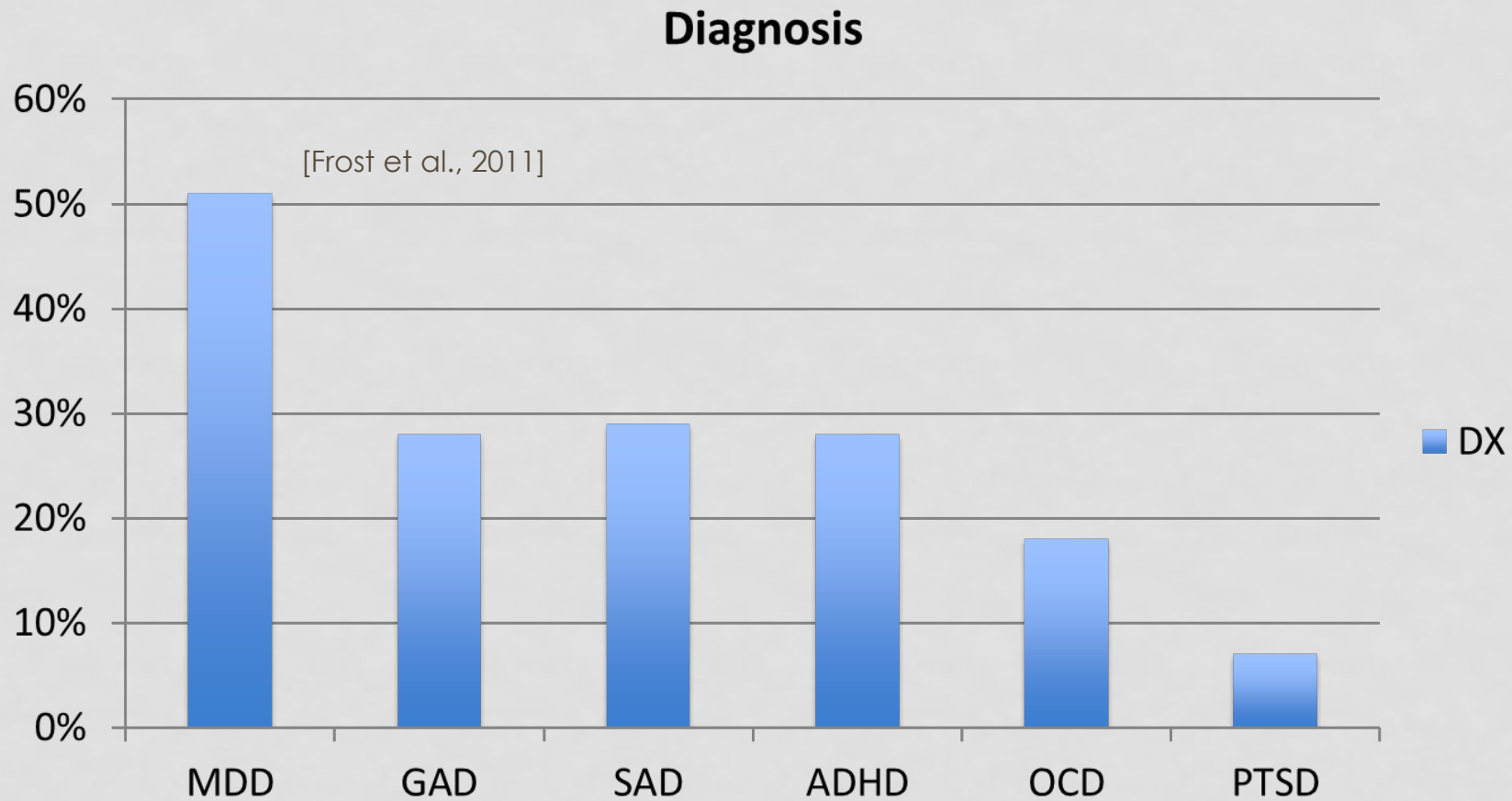
WORKING MEMORY WEAKNESSES

- Weaknesses in working memory make it difficult to stay on task when decluttering and organizing living environments.
- Weaknesses in working memory result in repeated failure to complete tasks and to follow through with multi-step projects such as decluttering and organizing living environments.

TIME MANAGEMENT WEAKNESSES

- Weaknesses in time awareness result in underestimation of time required to complete tasks and thereby interfere with planning and scheduling tasks effectively.

COMORBIDITIES: HOARDING DISORDER



OTHER CONSIDERATIONS

- Range of executive function weaknesses may co-exist in hoarding disorder apart from a co-occurring ADHD diagnosis.
- Age-related decrease in physical and cognitive capacity make it difficult to maintain living environment.
- Age-related decrease in social capacity lowers motivation to maintain living environment.
- Untreated or under-treated depression lowers motivation to maintain living environment.
- Relationship distress decreases willingness to accept help to maintain living environment.

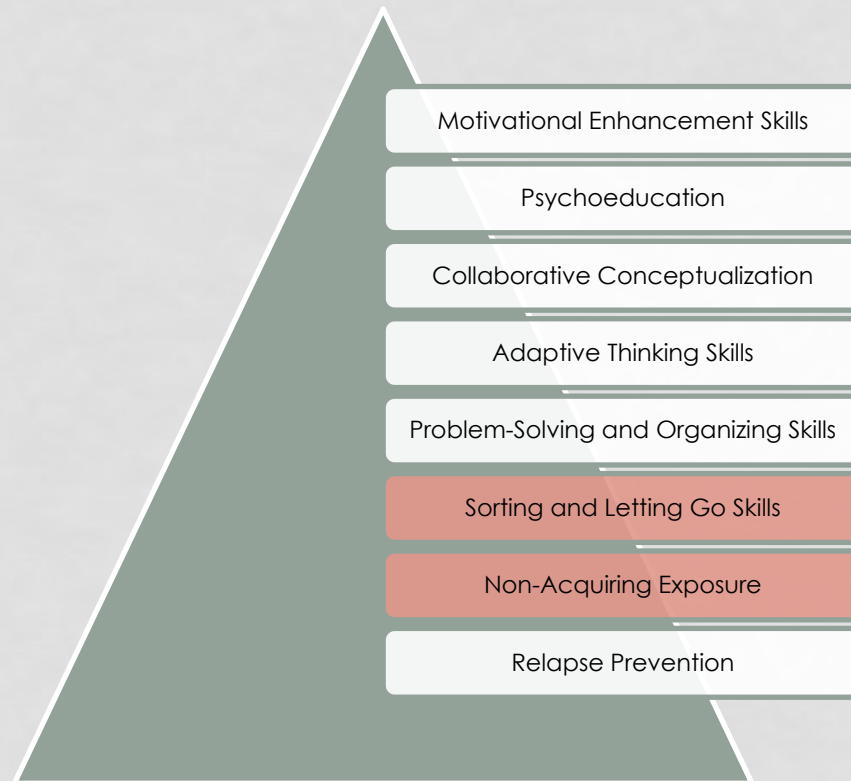
MEDICATION SUPPORTS

- Medications commonly prescribed for depressive and anxiety disorders (i.e., SSRI, SNRI) do not appear to significantly decrease primary symptoms of hoarding disorder but may decrease symptoms of co-occurring conditions which if untreated can limit motivation to learn and apply skills.
- Medications commonly prescribed for ADHD may improve ADHD-related factors that make it difficult to follow-through with learning and applying skills to manage clutter and disorganization in living environment.

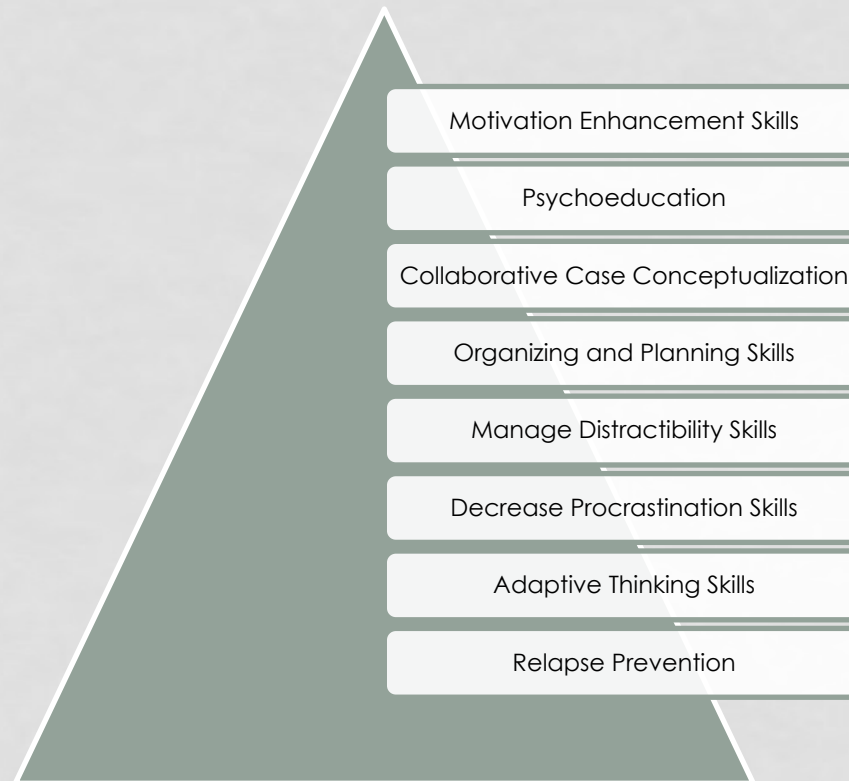
SKILLS THAT CAN HELP

COGNITIVE BEHAVIOR THERAPY

Hoarding Disorder



ADHD Disorder



SKILLS: MANAGE DISTRACTIBILITY

- Modify environment.
- Develop systems to track important items.
- Delay distraction technique.
- Prompting and cuing techniques.
- Timer.

RATIONALE: MANAGE DISTRACTIBILITY

- People with executive function weaknesses can have difficulty staying on task or staying on the most important task because they are easily distracted, which results in repeated failure to complete tasks on time and to follow through with multi-step projects.

DECREASE ENVIRONMENTAL DISTRACTIONS

- Identify factors in environment that increase or decrease distractibility.
- For factors that decrease distractibility, why?
- Develop plan to decrease environmental distractions (e.g., turn off notifications, close web browser, clear desk or cover clutter).

STEPS: DELAY DISTRACTION SKILL

1. How long can you focus before distracted?
2. Break down work to match attention span and set alarm for that time span.
3. Use pad or computer note, write distracting thought in a few words.
4. Use coping statements to continue: “I’ll worry about that later.” “This is not an A-task.” “I’ll do this later.”
5. At the end of the task, review notes.
6. Ask whether note is important: if not then cross out; if important, place on To-do list.

GUIDELINES: TIME TASKS

- Set timer for 25% of typical attention span (e.g., for 40-minute attention span set for 30 minutes). Keep timer on person.
- When timer sounds, ask self, “Am I still doing the task I was doing when I set the alarm, or did I get distracted?”
- If yes, reset timer. If no, return to task (perhaps shorten time) and restart task.

SKILLS: ORGANIZE AND PLAN

- Use calendar.
- Use transparent storage containers.
- Sort possessions into categories.
- Develop systems to organize and file paper.

RATIONALE: ORGANIZE PAPER

- People with executive function weaknesses often lack skills to organize items, such as important papers.
- Skills to organize and file important papers decreases the likelihood of significant consequences (missed payments, missed opportunities) and decreases feeling overwhelmed by simple tasks like paying bills.

STEPS: DEVELOP FILING SYSTEM

1. Identify simplest filing system that will work (e.g., file cabinet, drawer, accordion file).
2. Set up categories (e.g., taxes, medical records, pay stubs).
3. Consider sub-categories, but not many.
4. Sort and file paper 2-3 times each week: consider best time of day for optimal concentration and energy.

STEPS: ORGANIZE PAPER

1. Select place to sort and open all incoming paper: bills, mail, paperwork. Use basket, bowl or box (transparent is best).
2. Gather necessary items (e.g., checkbook, stamps, envelopes, calculator, address book, file folders) and move to designated place.
3. Develop discard rules for paper (e.g., paid bills at 6 months, junk mail on day it arrives, insurance policy at next renewal).
4. Calendar 2-3 times each week to sort paper: consider best time of day and attention span.

SKILLS: MANAGE TASKS

- Prioritize task.
- Graded task.
- Pomodoro technique.

RATIONALE: MANAGE TASKS SKILLS

- People with executive function weakness often have significant difficulties managing small and large tasks.
- Poor task management increases tendency to procrastinate.

PRIORITIZE: A, B, C DRAWERS

- **A-tasks:** Most important tasks to be completed by end of day or end of next day).
- **B-tasks:** Less important tasks to be completed over 1-2 weeks. Some sub-tasks are to be completed in short term.
- **C-tasks:** Least important tasks that are often the easiest to complete but often become ways to procrastinate.

GUIDELINES: PRIORITIZE TASKS

- Strive to distribute tasks across priorities (i.e., limit number of A-tasks).
- Break large tasks into subtasks and prioritize.
- Remember to complete **all** A-tasks before moving to B-tasks and complete **all** B-tasks before moving to C-tasks.

RATIONALE: BREAK DOWN TASKS

- People with executive function weakness often become easily overwhelmed by tasks.
- Learning to break tasks into subtasks improves ability to start tasks and to complete tasks.

STEPS: BREAK DOWN TASKS

1. Identify project or task you are putting off starting.
2. Divide task or project into as many steps or sub-tasks as you can think of: “What is the first thing to do to make this happen?” “What’s the next thing to do?”
3. Rate how confident you are (0 to 100%, where 100% is completely confident) that you will start and complete the step as described. Try for a confidence level of 90% or greater. If task is less than 90%, break that sub-task into smaller sub-tasks. To rate confidence, ask yourself the following questions.
4. Continue to break down each sub-task until you are 90% confident (or greater) that you can start and complete sub-task.
5. Move sub-tasks onto To-Do list, prioritize, and schedule.

QUESTIONS: RATE CONFIDENCE

- How long did it take me to complete similar tasks in the past?
- How long did it take me to complete similar tasks when under pressure?
- How long did it take me to complete similar tasks when I was working efficiently?
- How long does it take a friend or coworker to complete similar tasks?

STEPS: POMODORO TECHNIQUE

1. **Choose a task:** Select a single task to focus on during the Pomodoro.
2. **Set the timer:** Start a 25-minute timer (the Pomodoro).
3. **Work without distractions:** Focus solely on the task until the timer rings.
4. **Take a short break:** After the timer, take a 5-minute break to relax and recharge.
5. **Repeat and take a longer break:** Repeat steps 2-4 three more times, then take a longer break (15-30 minutes) after completing four Pomodoros.

SUMMARY

- Both hoarding disorder and ADHD include significant executive function weaknesses that result in cluttered living and working environments.
- Although hoarding disorder and ADHD result in a cluttered and disorganized living and working environments the mechanisms assumed to maintain clutter and disorganization may differ in several ways.
- Cognitive behavior therapy is an effective treatment for both hoarding disorder and ADHD and share many (but not all) of the same skills.